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state Assembly - Council staffer eyes Dababneh's Valley seat - Tricia Robbins Kasson touts revitalization work

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Tricia Robbins Kasson thinks electing a woman to replace Matt Dababneh in the California Assembly would be a big step toward curtailing sexual harassment in the state Capitol.

Even better, the Democrat says, would be electing a woman with the economic-development experience needed to address one of the west San Fernando Valley's biggest challenges.

Robbins Kasson, 46, a Tarzana resident who touts her work on downtown and West Valley revitalization as a Los Angeles City Council staffer, has declared her candidacy for the Assembly District 45 seat left vacant when Dababneh resigned after women accused him of sexual misconduct.

Other candidates include Democrats Jesse Gabriel, Samantha Stevens and Ankur Patel and Republican Justin Clark. A special election has been set for April 3, with a runoff June 5 if nobody gets an outright majority. It's one of four special elections for state legislative seats on those dates.

"I think I'm qualified to bring jobs and economic opportunity to the Valley and to change the culture in Sacramento," Robbins Kasson said in an interview.

Referring to the resignations of Dababneh and Assemblyman Raul Bocanegra and the investigation of state Sen. Tony Mendoza, D-Artesia, over sexual harassment charges, Robbins Kasson said this is a moment for overdue change.

"It's time to have more women in positions of authority," Robbins Kasson said. "We've done our work. Women are graduating from college as never before. We're qualified, we're capable. I believe when you have more women who are part of the conversations, it shifts the conversations."

A 2017 graduate of Emerge California, a program that recruits and trains Democratic women to run for office, Robbins Kasson said she didn't plan to run for the Dababneh seat and planned to support L.A. Community College Trustee Andra Hoffman. Then Hoffman opted not to run for the Assembly, so Robbins Kasson jumped in.

Now Hoffman has endorsed Robbins Kasson, as has Bob Blumenfield, the area's L.A. city councilman and former assemblyman, and Howard Berman, the former congressman.

As Blumenfield's economic development deputy the past two years, Robbins Kasson has worked on creating programs to bring economic development to Sherman Way in Reseda and Canoga Park, "main street" areas that have suffered from the shift to mall shopping. Earlier, on the staff of City Councilman Jose Huizar, she worked on the Bringing Back Broadway revitalization. Working for a private-sector public-policy consultant, she dealt with the Warner Center 2035 Specific Plan.

If she's elected to the state Legislature, Robbins Kasson said, she'll work to help West Valley residents get good jobs by promoting educational and apprentice programs and access to child care.

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